DUX_A1_CL

Craigslist UK Redesign Project

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1. Aims and Justification for Website Development

Overview

Craigslist is a community-driven classifieds platform used for buying, selling, trading, and requesting or offering services at a local level. It handles listings for everyday items such as furniture, electronics, and odd jobs. Despite its wide reach, the current Craigslist UK website (london.craigslist.org) presents significant usability and accessibility deficiencies that hinder engagement and alienate large segments of the population.

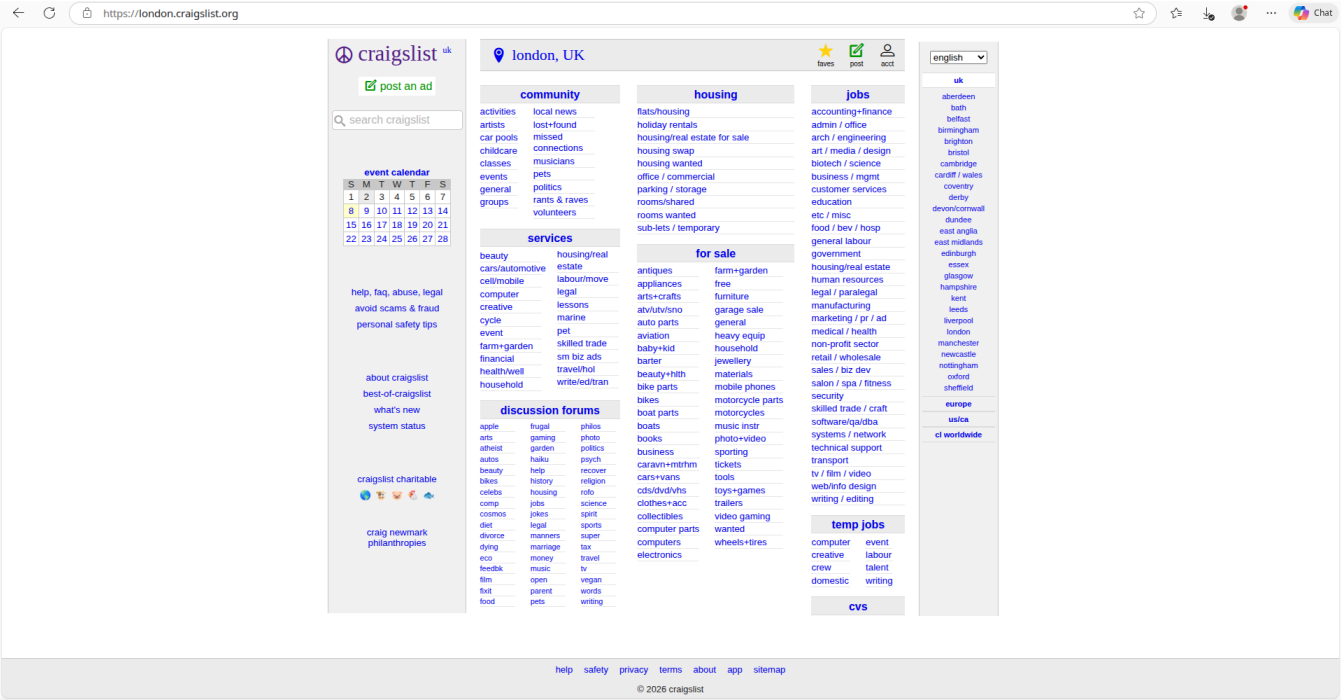
The aim of this project is to investigate those deficiencies, justify the need for a redesigned website, and produce an improved design that addresses identified problems while remaining faithful to Craigslist's community-classifieds purpose.

To acheive this we will break it down into 3 parts: evaluation of business needs, and identified issues; Target Audience, User Personas, Stories ; Design Wireframes, Evaluate improved accessibility and usability

Business Needs and Identified Issues

1.1 Outdated Visual Design and Steep Learning Curve

The current Craigslist interface relies entirely on text-based navigation with no visual hierarchy, icons, or graphical signposting. PhD researcher Nihal Nayak (Harvard University) characterised the site as "out-of-fashion" with a steep learning curve (Nayak, 2019). Because so few modern websites use this style, new users must actively learn the interface rather than applying familiar web conventions — a direct violation of the usability principle of **consistency with external standards** (Nielsen, 1994).



> **Description:** Screenshot of london.craigslist.org homepage showing text-only layout, lack of sectional dividers, and absence of visual hierarchy.

1.2 Non-Intuitive Search Functionality

The search box is positioned in the top-left corner beneath the page title. While visible, it contains no graphical button or icon to trigger a search. Users must know to press Enter/Return — an interaction pattern largely abandoned by modern web services. Competitor platforms eBay UK and Gumtree both use clearly labelled, graphically styled search buttons that align with established user expectations.

ebay

Search for anything

eBay LIVE | Electronics | Fashion | Selling | Seasonal | Deals | eBa

Pokémon grails from '96 to now

Bid on 30 finds at retro prices and nonstop streams on eBay Live.

From 2/27 to 3/1.

Tune in

Trending in Sneakers

craigslist uk

post an ad

search craigslist

event calendar

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21

help, faq, abuse, legal
avoid scams & fraud
personal safety tips

about craigslist
best-of-craigslist
what's new
system status

london, UK

faves post acct

community

activities
artists
car pools
childcare
classes
events
general
groups
local news
lost+found
missed connections
musicians
pets
politics
rants & raves
volunteers

services

beauty
cars/automotive
cell/mobile
computer
creative
cycle
event
farm+garden
financial
health/well
household
housing/real estate
labour/move

housing

flats/housing
holiday rentals
housing/real estate for sale
housing swap
housing wanted
office / commercial
parking / storage
rooms/shared
rooms wanted
sub-lets / temporary

for sale

antiques
appliances
arts+crafts
atv/utv/sno
auto parts
aviation
baby+kid
barter
beauty+hlth
bike parts
bikes
boat parts
boats
books
farm+garden
free
furniture
garage sale
general
heavy equip
household
jewellery
materials
mobile phones
motorcycle parts
motorcycles

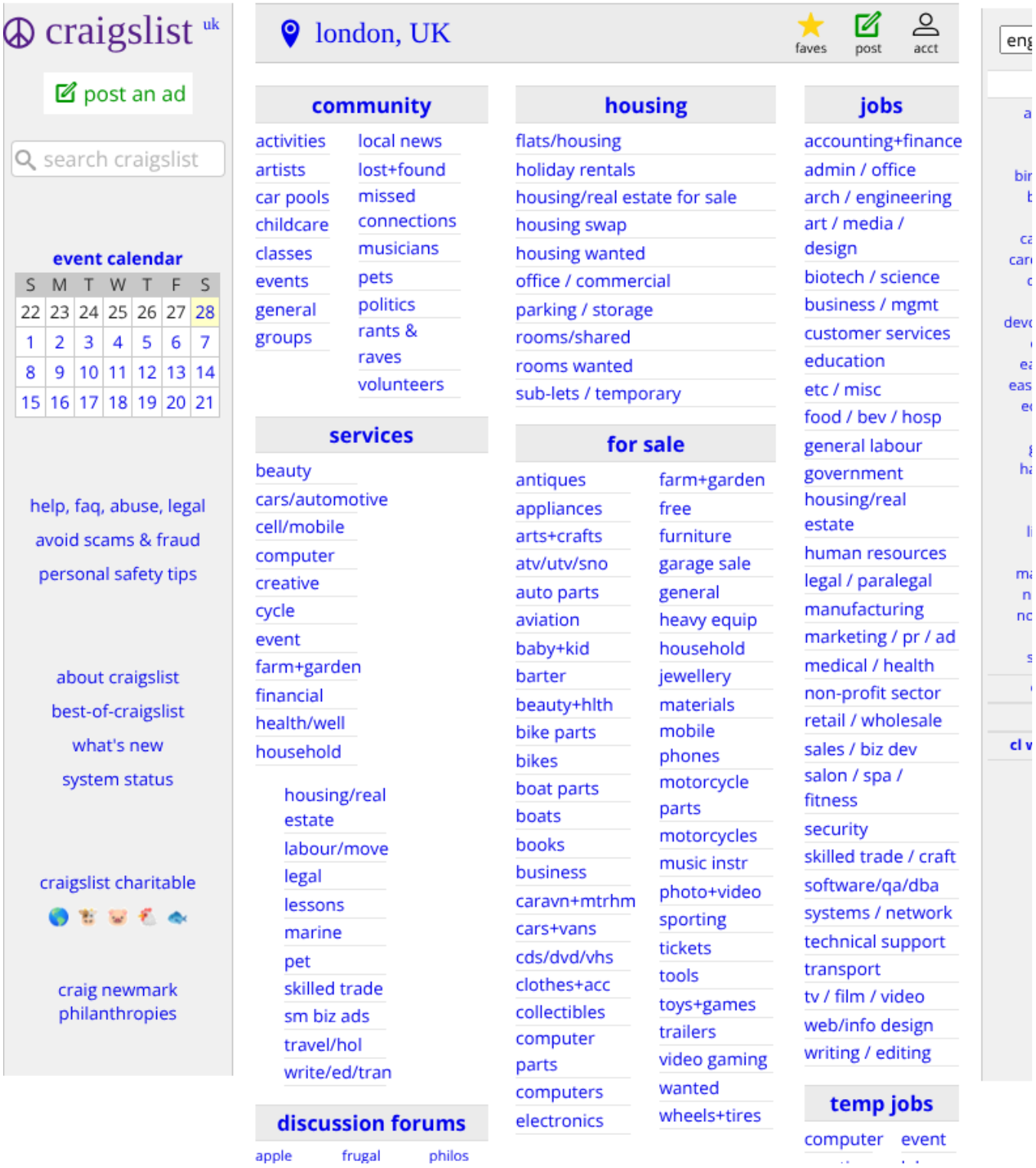
jobs

accounting+finance
admin / office
arch / engineering
art / media / design
biotech / science
business / mgmt
customer services
education
etc / misc
food / bev / hosp
general labour
government
housing/real estate
human resources
legal / paralegal
manufacturing
marketing / pr / ad
medical / health
non-profit sector
retail / wholesale
sales / biz dev
salon / spa / fitness
security

> **Description:** Side-by-side comparison of Craigslist's search bar (no button) vs. eBay UK (prominent search buttons).

1.3 Lack of Mobile Responsiveness

Craigslist does not implement responsive design patterns such as dropdown menus, collapsible navigation, or touch-optimised tap targets. A substantial and growing proportion of web traffic originates from mobile devices, particularly among younger demographics who prefer a mobile-first experience. The absence of responsive design means content overflows on small screens, elements fail to scale correctly even when browser zoom is applied, and touch targets are too small for reliable interaction.



> **Description:** Annotated screenshot of Craigslist rendered on a mobile viewport, illustrating layout overflow and unscaled text elements.

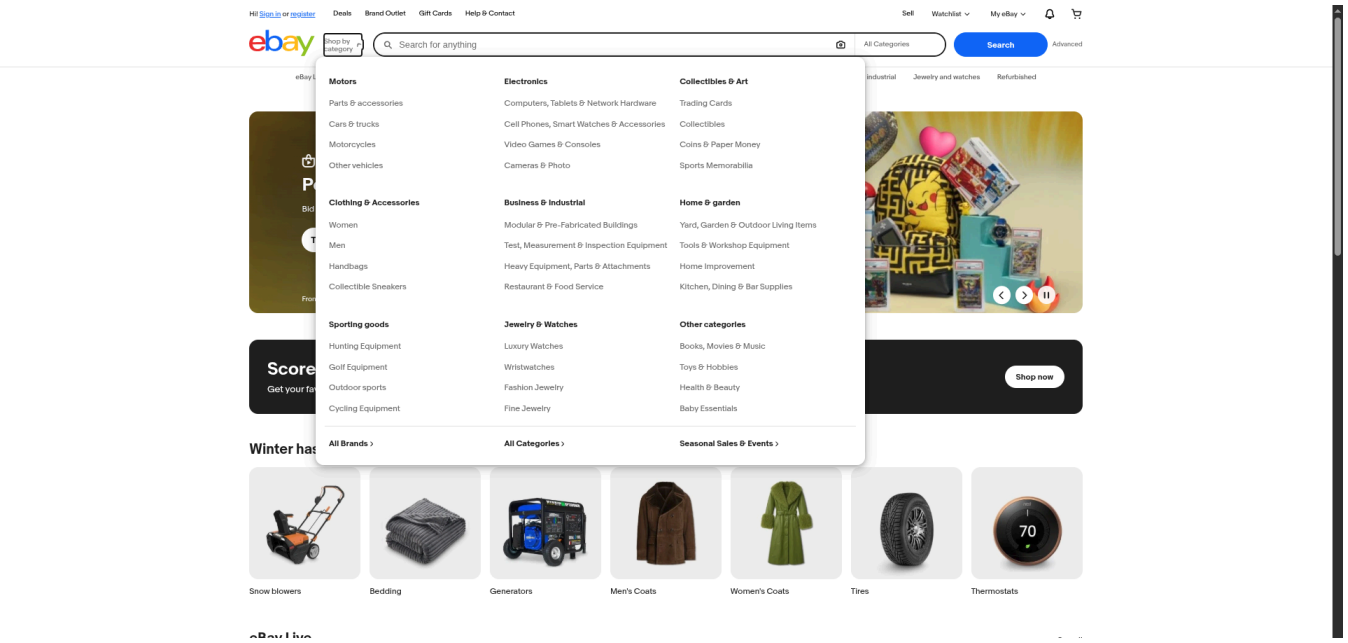
1.4 Poor Accessibility

The site uses inconsistent semantic landmark regions, provides minimal colour contrast differentiation between content areas, and offers no ARIA attributes or skip-navigation links. This makes the site difficult or impossible to use for people relying on screen readers, keyboard navigation, or assistive technologies — a failure to meet WCAG 2.1 Level AA standards (W3C, 2018).

The sites semantic landmark region has no deliniation between the topmost row, that selects the region, category allows access to posting and account information, and the search functions this means every time a screenreader or braile device goes over the header section they read both navigation information and site controls (region, category, post creation, and account information), instead of what should happen where navigation search and main are in three identifiable sections for those tools.

1.5 Competitive Analysis Summary

Feature	Craigslist UK	eBay UK	Gumtree
Graphical search button	✗	✓	✓
Category icons	✗	✓	✓
Mobile responsive layout	✗	✓	✓
Visual section separation	✗	✓	✓
Accessible colour contrast	✗	✓	Partial
Dropdown / hamburger menus	✗	✓	✓



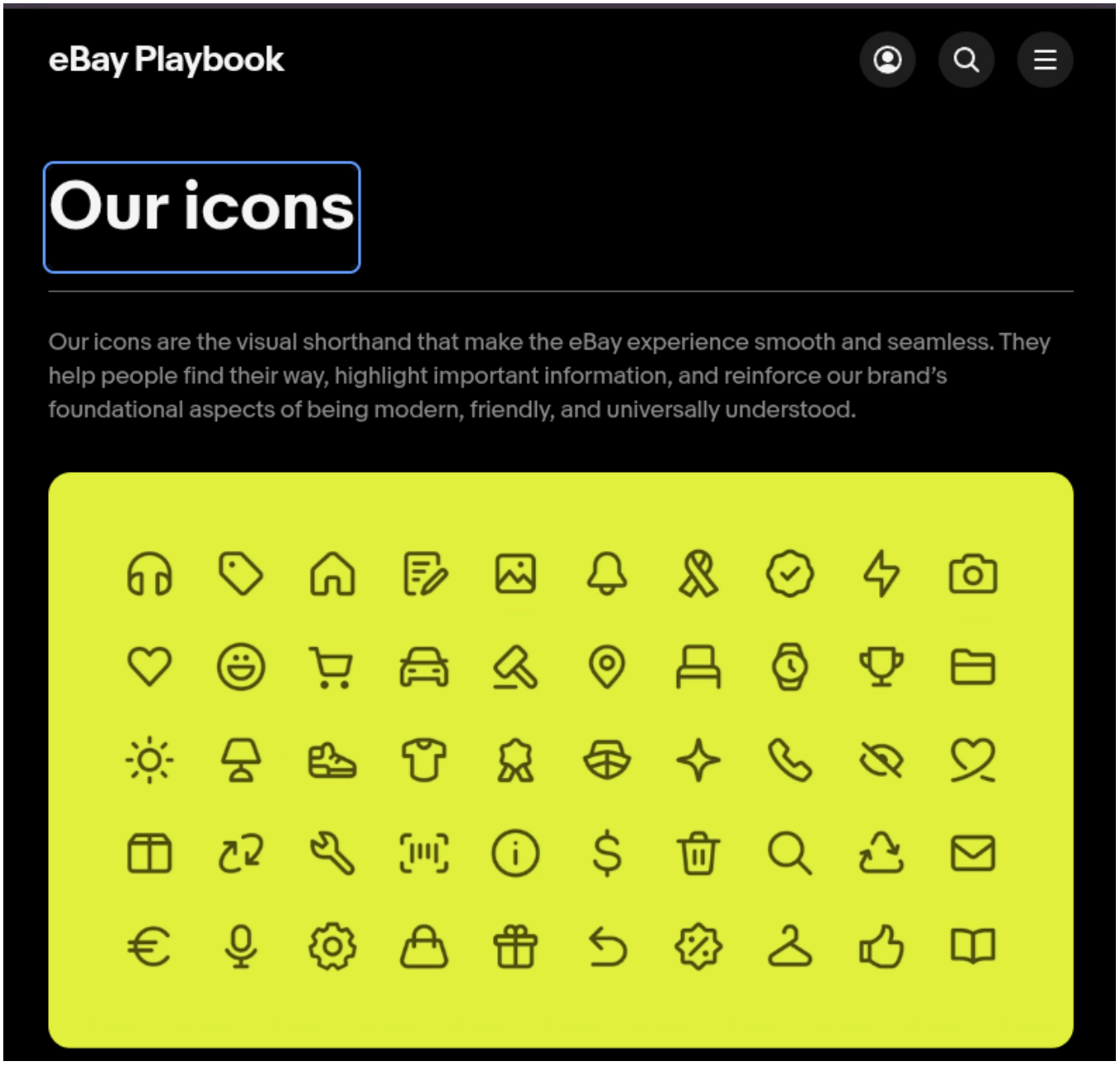
> **Description:** Screenshot of eBay UK homepage showing icons, responsive grid layout, and popup navigation menus.

1.6 Analysis of eBay Iconography

eBay hosts their own dedicated design documentation site called the **eBay Playbook**, which is dedicated to showcasing how they as a business function and deliver their level of service.

The site has a whole page dedicated to eBay's iconography and their own icon library. This library includes purpose-built icons covering the majority of their product categories — headphones for electronics, a car for automotive, footwear, a t-shirt for clothing, a lamp shade for home furnishings, a bed frame for furniture, boats for leisure, and many more.

Unlike craigslist these icons are synonymous to the user have alternative text for screenreaders and are used across ebay apps, sites, pages, and services, and they are considered by ebay to be a **foundation** of their design. These icons and more can be found at playbook.ebay.com/foundations/iconography/our-icons



> **Description:** Screenshot of ebay UK Playbook page on iconography, demonstrating eBay's structured icon library used across their platform for intuitive category navigation.

Justification for Development

The evidence above demonstrates a clear and urgent business need for website redevelopment. The purpose behind the redesign is to:

- Reduce the learning curve for first-time and infrequent visitors by aligning with contemporary web design conventions.
- Improve accessibility to meet WCAG 2.1 Level AA standards, enabling use by people with disabilities.
- Introduce mobile-responsive layouts to capture and retain traffic from mobile users.
- Implement intuitive graphical navigation and prominent search functionality to reduce abandonment and improve conversion rates.
- Maintain Craigslist's community-classifieds identity while making it competitive against modern alternatives.

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2. Target Audience, User Personas, User Stories, Tasks and Acceptance Criteria

Target Audience

Craigslist UK serves a broad community of users across the UK who wish to buy, sell, trade, or seek/offer local services. Key audience segments include:

- **First-time visitors** exploring online classifieds for the first time or new to Craigslist specifically.
- **Returning visitors** who use the site periodically for specific needs (e.g., selling items every few months).
- **Frequent visitors** who rely on the platform regularly for business or personal activity.
- Additional segments include buyers, sellers, landlords, job seekers, and community members posting local events.

Persona 1 — Sarah (First-Time Visitor)

Attribute	Detail
Age	40
Occupation	Carer
Location	Hertfordshire
Devices	iPhone (primary), Windows laptop
Tech comfort	Comfortable with basic web navigation; prefers graphical interfaces
Accessibility needs	Dyslexia (uses screen reader / text-to-speech); occasional hand tremors (requires large touch targets); relies on voice search on mobile

Background: Sarah has never used Craigslist before and is exploring online classifieds to source affordable second-hand furniture for a client. She is tech-savvy but prefers clear, visually structured layouts over text-heavy pages. She finds Craigslist's current interface overwhelming and has encountered issues with elements not scaling correctly when browser zoom is applied.

User Stories — Sarah

#	User Story
S1	As a **first-time visitor**, I want to **search for second-hand furniture using a visible search button**, so that **I can find relevant listings without needing to know keyboard shortcuts**.
S2	As a **user with dyslexia**, I want the **website to use clear, simple language with generous spacing and readable fonts**, so that **I can browse listings without cognitive overload**.
S3	As a **mobile user with hand tremors**, I want **large, clearly labelled buttons and touch targets**, so that **I can navigate the site reliably on my smartphone**.

Tasks — Sarah

- Navigate to the homepage and locate the search bar.
- Enter a search term ("second-hand sofa") and initiate the search using an on-screen button (without pressing Enter).
- Filter results by location (Hertfordshire) and price range.
- Open a listing and view item details including images, price, description, and seller contact information.
- Use a screen reader or text-to-speech to access listing content.

Acceptance Criteria — Sarah

S1 – Search functionality:

> *Given* Sarah is on the homepage, *when* she types "sofa" into the search bar and taps the graphical search button, *then* she should be presented with a list of relevant local listings within 3 seconds, without needing to press Enter.

S2 – Readability:

> *Given* Sarah opens a listing page, *when* she reads the listing description, *then* all text must use a sans-serif font of at least 16px, with a line-height of at least 1.5, and a minimum colour contrast ratio of 4.5:1 (WCAG 2.1 AA).

S3 – Touch targets:

> *Given* Sarah is using the site on her iPhone, *when* she attempts to tap any button, link, or interactive element, *then* all tap targets must be a minimum of 44×44 CSS pixels in size (WCAG 2.1 Success Criterion 2.5.5).

Persona 2 — Dexter (Returning Visitor)

Attribute	Detail
Age	35
Occupation	Graphic Designer
Location	London
Devices	MacBook Pro (primary), Android tablet
Tech comfort	High; experienced with web tools; critical of poor UI/UX
Accessibility needs	Arthritis in hands (keyboard navigation preferred; difficulty with precise mouse control); deuteranopia (red-green colour blindness)

Background: Dexter returns to Craigslist every few months to sell old electronics or look for items in familiar categories. He has browser extensions for magnification and high-contrast mode but wishes sites were accessible by default. He values auto-save on forms and struggles with small input fields. His design background means he quickly dismisses cluttered or outdated interfaces.

User Stories — Dexter

#	User Story
D1	As a **returning visitor**, I want the **website to remember my preferred listing categories**, so that **I can get back to relevant content quickly without re-configuring my search each time**.
D2	As a **keyboard user**, I want to **navigate the entire site without a mouse**, so that **I can use the platform comfortably despite limited hand dexterity**.
D3	As a **user with deuteranopia**, I want **status indicators and important information to be conveyed through shape or text labels rather than colour alone**, so that **I do not miss critical information due to colour-coded cues**.

Tasks — Dexter

- Log in to an existing account using keyboard navigation only (Tab, Enter, arrow keys).
- Navigate to the "Electronics" category using the keyboard and locate a previously posted listing.
- Create a new listing: enter title, description, price, and upload an image, with auto-save enabled.
- Review form validation messages that do not rely solely on red/green colour indicators.
- Submit the listing and receive a confirmation that is accessible via keyboard focus.

Acceptance Criteria — Dexter

D1 – Returning user preferences:

> *Given* Dexter has previously browsed the "Electronics" category, *when* he returns to the homepage, *then* the site should surface a "Recently Viewed" or "Your Categories" section that links back to Electronics without requiring a new search.

D2 – Keyboard navigation:

> *Given* Dexter is using keyboard-only navigation, *when* he tabs through the page, *then* every interactive element (links, buttons, inputs, dropdowns) must be reachable via Tab and operable via Enter/Space, with a clearly visible focus indicator at all times (WCAG 2.1 SC 2.4.7).

D3 – Colour-independent information:

> *Given* Dexter is viewing a form with validation errors, *when* an input fails validation, *then* the error must be communicated through a text label and/or icon — not through a colour change alone — ensuring it is perceivable to users with colour vision deficiencies (WCAG 2.1 SC 1.4.1).

Persona 3 - Lana (Frequent Visitor)

Attribute	Detail
Age	22
Occupation	Student
Location	Hertfordshire
Devices	Android (primary), Windows Desktop
Tech comfort	Comfortable with a range of digital tools; prefers structured interfaces with clear, simple navigation.
Accessibility needs	ADHD (prefers clear, structured layouts with concise text); visual sensitivity (prefers soft contrast and minimal glare); relies on search filters and saved preferences.

Background: Lana uses Craigslist weekly to search for part-time work and tutoring opportunities. She relies on structured, easy to navigate interfaces. She finds the text-heavy layout of Craigslist challenging to scan a prefers filtering tools to quickly narrow down her results

User Stories — Lana

#	User Story
S1	As a **frequent visitor**, I want to **filter my search results by category and location**, so that **I can quickly find relevant listing without being overwhelmed by irrelevant options**.
S2	As a **user with ADHD**, I want the **website to have clear visual hierarchy and concise descriptions**, so that **I can focus on the most important information without distractions**.
S3	As a **user with visual sensitivity**, I want **the website to offer a dark mode or soft contrast option,**, so that **I can browse without experiencing discomfort**.

Tasks — Lana

- Navigate to the homepage and locate the search bar, ensuring the search button is clearly visible and easy to tap on her smartphone.
- Enter a search term ("affordable bikes") and initiate the search by tapping the search button (without needing to use the keyboard).
- Apply filters to refine search results
- Open a listing and view item details such as price, description, seller information, and images, ensuring the content is well-structured with clear headings and sufficient spacing.

Acceptance Criteria — Lana

S1 – Filtering by category and location:

> *Given* Lana is on search results page, *when* she applies a filter for location and selects a category, *then* the page should refresh and show listings that match those filters.

S2 – Structured content and accessibility:

> *Given* Lana is on a listing page,, *when* she uses a screen reader *then* all listing details must be properly structured with clear and accessible HTML markup, so she can easily access the content.

S3 – Search results accuracy:

> *Given* Lana has entered a search term into the search bar, *when* the search results are displayed, *then* the listings shown should match the search term and be sorted by relevance, location adn price.

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3. Design — Wireframes, Accessibility & Usability

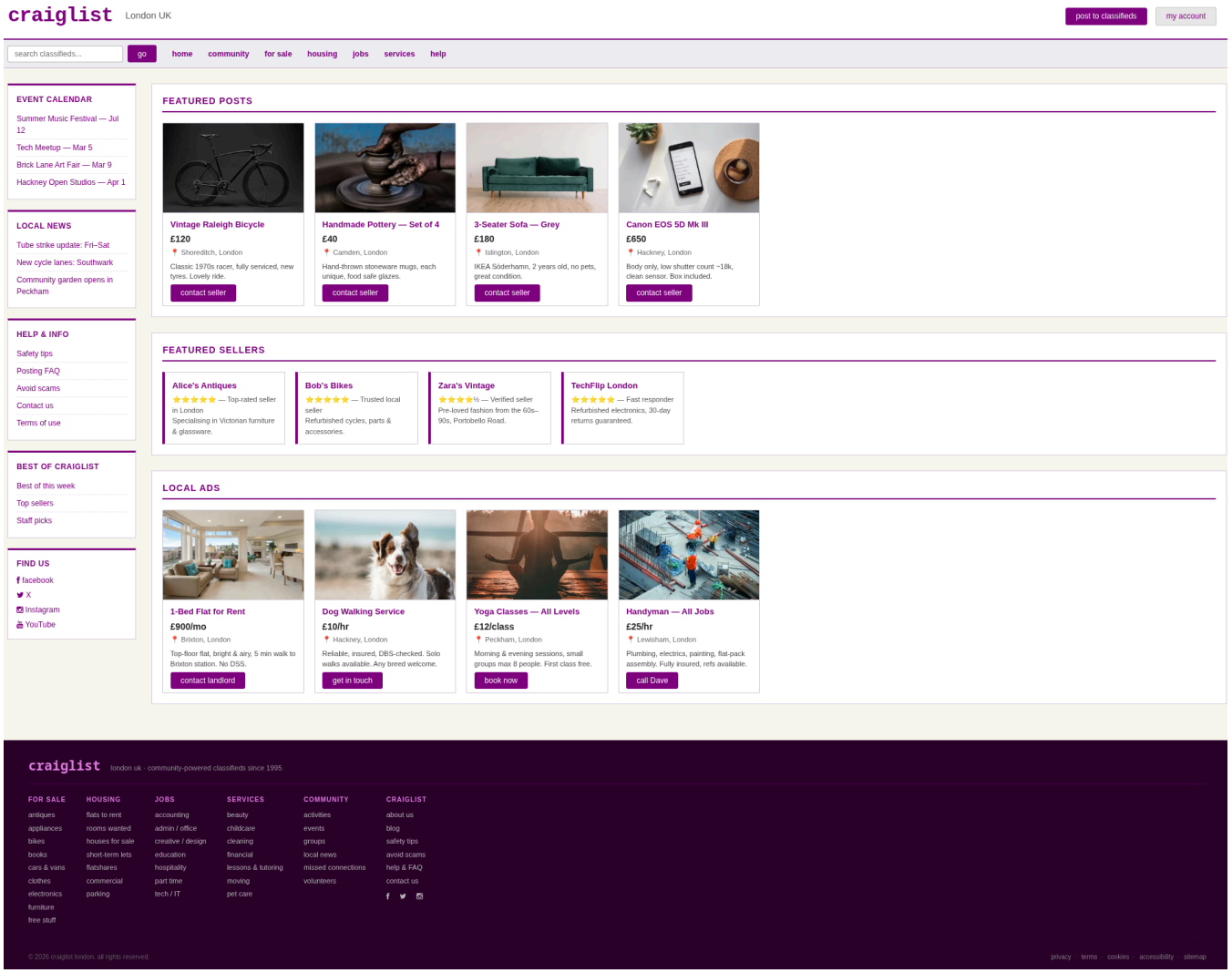
> *This section will be completed following the creation of wireframe designs. It should include:*
>
> - *Wireframe images for at least 3 pages or page areas (desktop or mobile)*
> - *Annotations explaining specific design decisions with reference to WCAG 2.1, usability heuristics (e.g., Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics), and WAI-ARIA where applicable*
> - *Notes on how each design choice addresses the needs of the user personas above*

3.1 Design Principles Applied

The wireframes will be guided by the following standards and principles:

- **WCAG 2.1 Level AA** — minimum contrast ratios, keyboard navigability, focus indicators, text alternatives for non-text content, and no reliance on colour alone.
- **WAI-ARIA landmarks** — use of `<nav>`, `<main>`, `<aside>`, `<header>`, and `<footer>` semantic regions to support screen reader navigation.
- **Nielsen's Usability Heuristics** — particularly visibility of system status, consistency with external standards, error prevention, and recognition over recall.
- **Mobile-first responsive design** — layouts designed for small screens first and scaled up, with touch targets of at least 44×44px.

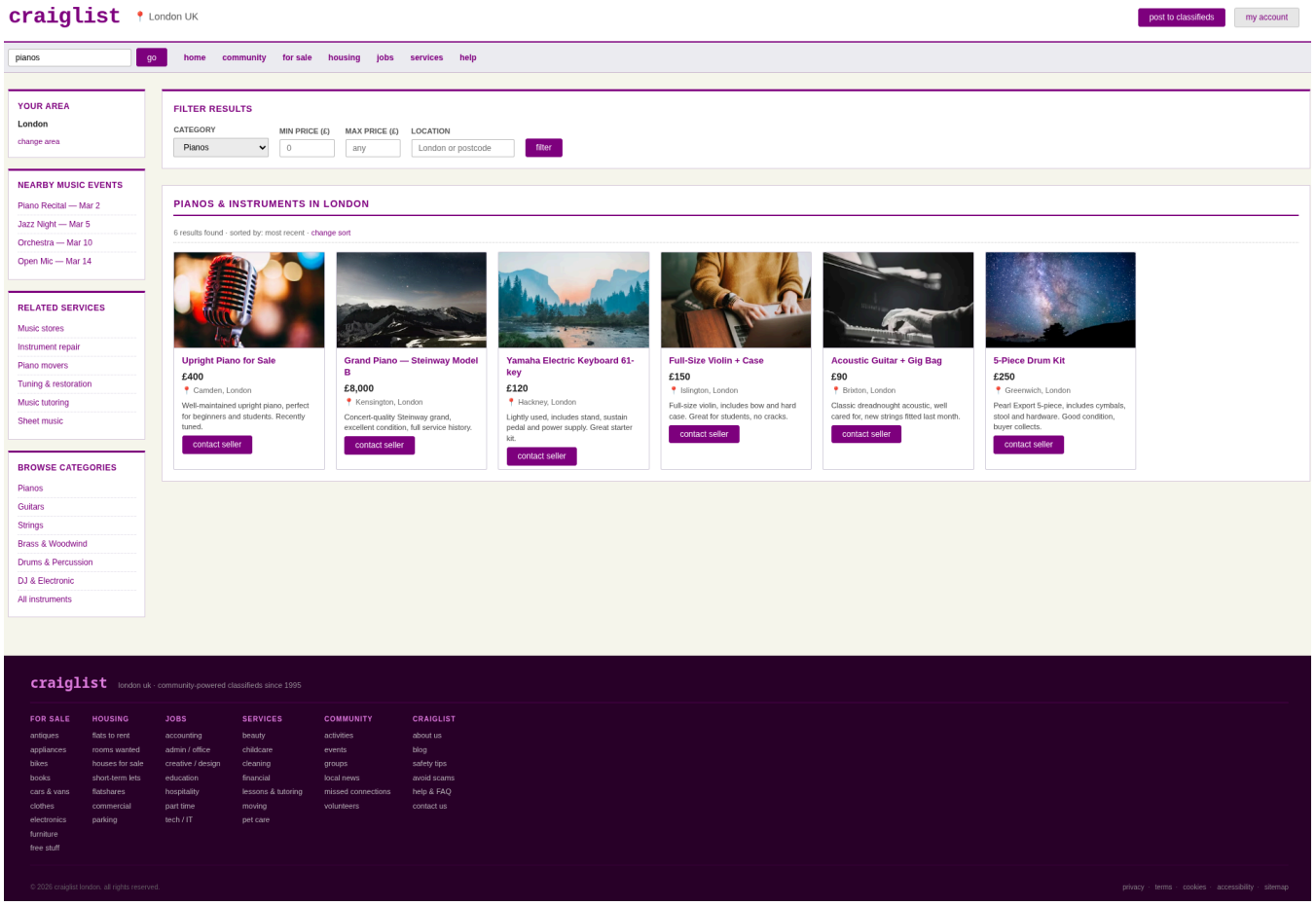
3.2 Page / Area 1 — Homepage



Design Notes:

- Prominent search bar with a clearly labelled graphical search button, addressing Sarah's need to initiate search without keyboard shortcuts.
- Category grid using icons alongside text labels, reducing reliance on pure text navigation.
- Sufficient spacing between interactive elements to support users with hand tremors or motor impairments.
- "Recently Viewed" section for returning users such as Dexter.

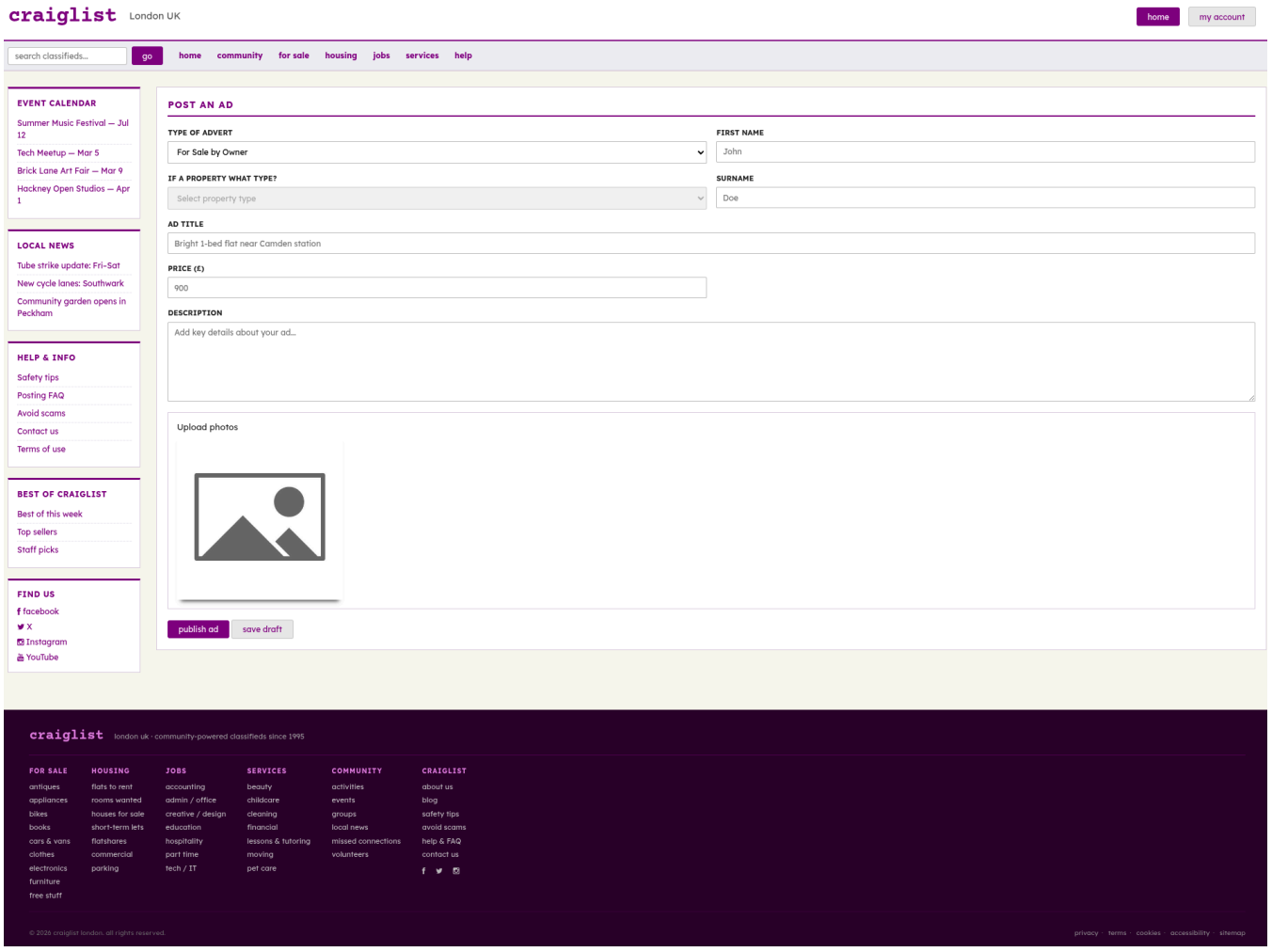
3.3 Page / Area 2 — Search Results Page



Design Notes:

- Filter panel accessible via keyboard with clearly labelled checkboxes and dropdowns.
- Results presented as cards with thumbnail images, title, price, and location — reducing cognitive load for users with dyslexia.
- Sorting and filtering controls do not rely on colour alone for active/inactive states.

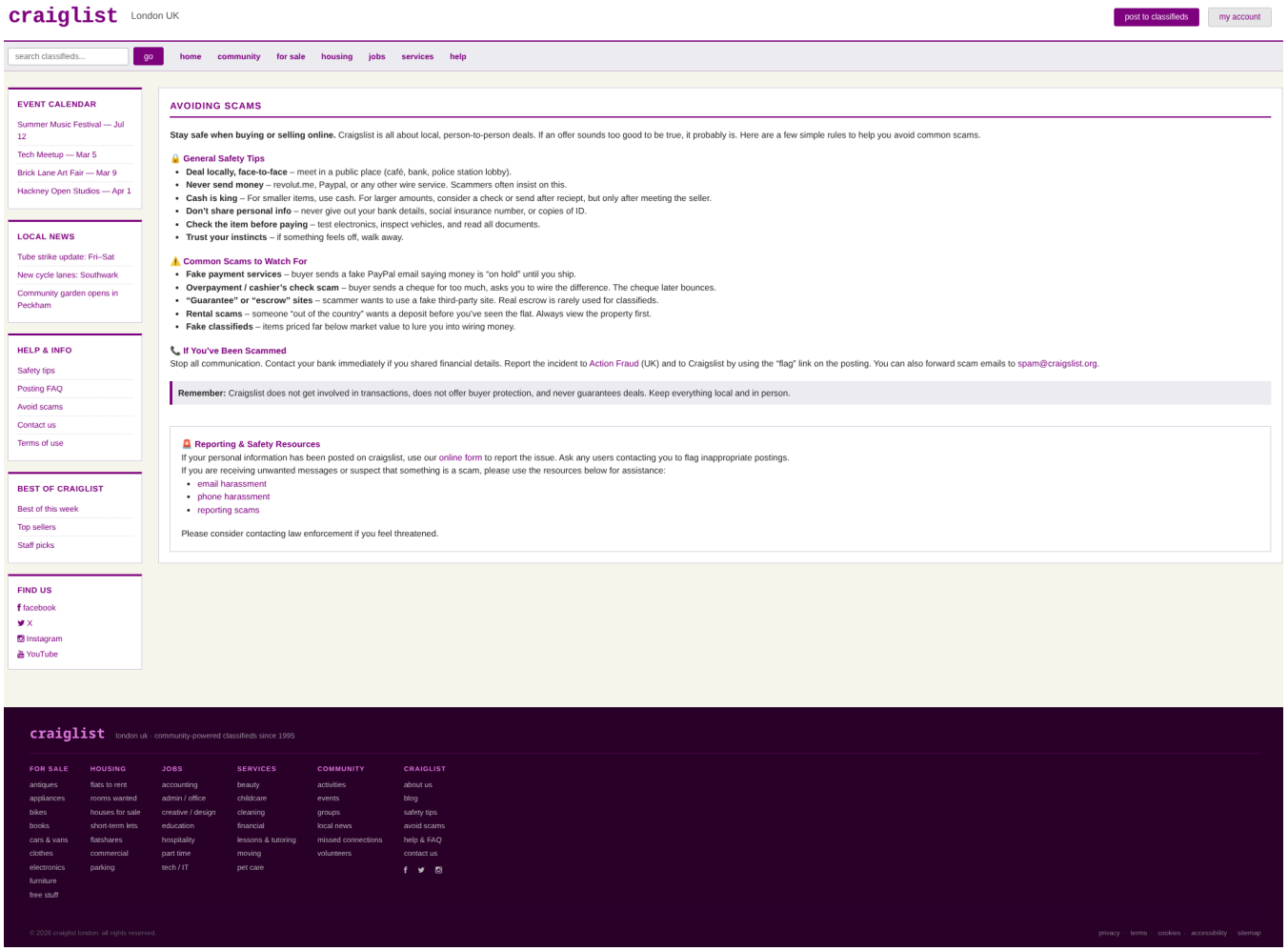
3.4 Page / Area 3 — Post a Listing Form



Design Notes:

- Large input fields with visible labels (not placeholder-only labels, which disappear on focus).
- Auto-save functionality at defined intervals to prevent data loss for users with slower input speeds.

3.5 Page / Area 4 — Avoiding Scams



Design Notes:

- Single-page clarity so all scam-related guidance is presented in one continuous, easy-to-read page without forcing users to navigate away.
- Actionable steps for each tip, showing what to watch for, how to verify listings, and what to do if something seems suspicious.
- Readable layout organized with headings, bullet points, and icons for quick scanning and avoiding walls of text.
- Accessible interactions that are fully keyboard and screen reader friendly, with clearly labeled and focusable warnings and examples.
- Persistent guidance so important warnings about buyer safety are always shown no matter the reason someone clicked on the page.
- Seamless navigation that allows users to leave the page without multiple back clicks while keeping top bar, navbar, and sidebar consistent and functional.
- Mobile-first design with touch-friendly elements and responsive layout for usability on all screen sizes.

4. Reflection on the Design Process

4.1 Key Decisions, trade-offs and Successes

The redesign process started with use critically assessing the exisiting craiglist UK site against modern design standards. This analysis npted some serioius deficiencies which extended across the entire site and few were isolated.

A central debate emerged amongst the team: how much could we get done for craiglist and how much of the original minimalistic design could we keep.Its sparesness was part of its identiuty, but it also created a steep learning curve (nayak, 2019). We resolved this by as and where we could maintaining the existing text based buttons, and selectables while also adding icons, this solved two issues for us maintaining that minimalistic approach, while also being adapted for screen readers there was no need to add alt text to our facebook icon as it was followed by facebook or our vehicles icon as it was also followed by the word Vehicles.

4.2 Accessibility as a Foundation

Accessibility was not an afterthought of our project unlike the original site, We mapped WCAG 21 Level AA sucess criteria to every one of ourour design decisions:

Each icon/symbol/text maintained acceptable levels of contrast (4.5:1), verified by a check using [webaim contrast checker](), we maintained keyboard navigation by utilising keyboard compatible elements and avoiding dynamic popups where possible.

Semantic Elements - Key regions were landmarked in the navigation and page structure to improve compatibility with assistive technologies. The redesign separates the page into clearly defined

,
,
,
, and
sections so that screen readers can interpret the structure of the page correctly. This directly addresses one of the major accessibility problems identified in the original Craigslist site where navigation, search, and account controls were grouped together without clear separation.

By structuring the layout using semantic landmarks, users relying on screen readers or braille displays can skip between major areas of the page instead of being forced to read through the entire header each time they load a new page. This significantly improves efficiency and aligns the design with WCAG 2.1 guidelines relating to navigable page structure.

Another accessibility consideration was avoiding the use of colour alone to communicate important information. For example, validation errors in forms are supported with icons and descriptive text labels rather than simply changing the colour of an input field. This ensures that users with colour vision deficiencies such as deuteranopia are still able to understand when an error has occurred and how to correct it.

4.3 Team Collaboration and Workflow

The design process was collaborative between all three team members, with responsibilities shared across research, wireframing, and documentation. Initial analysis of the Craigslist interface was conducted collectively, with each team member identifying usability and accessibility issues through heuristic evaluation and comparison with competitor platforms such as eBay and Gumtree.

Once the key issues had been identified, the team began developing wireframes to address those problems while still maintaining Craigslist's core identity as a simple community classifieds platform. Feedback was exchanged throughout the process, allowing designs to be refined and improved iteratively.

Using a shared repository allowed the team to track contributions and maintain version control of the project documentation and design files. This also ensured transparency in individual contributions and made it easier to combine different sections of the assignment into a cohesive final report.

The shared repository was only instituted when neccessary, prior to this a shared drive was used when forming the ideas, and analysing the competitors. It was the responsibility of Kai Young to transfer this over and thus is why other team members havent collaborated within those sections on the logs.

4.4 Overall Reflection

Overall, the redesign process demonstrated to us how, legacy platforms can benefit from modern usability practices and how very popular coners on the internet are still years behind in levels of design and usability especially when it comes to their accessibility. By introducing clearer visual heirachy, improved navigaion and a full interface rredesign. We were able to transform craiglist from a site only compatible with basic support features of accessiblity tools like screen readers, braille etc, to one supported by loads of complex accessibility tools, but also for individuals with impairments that don't have accessibility devices our surface level website is more accessible with greater contrast etc.

Through this project the team gained a deeper understanding of the relationship between usability, accessibility, and user-centred design, and how these principles can be applied to improve real-world digital platforms.

5. Contributors

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Daniel Zhang	dz25aaa@herts.ac.uk

> *Update this table with actual emails. All Team Members have to have made commits to the repository*

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6. References

Nayak, N. (2019) *A UI/UX Critique of Craigslist*. Medium. Available at: https://medium.com/@nihalnayak/a-ui-ux-critique-of-craigslist-e3b235824479 (Accessed: 8 February 2026).

Nielsen, J. (1994) '10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design', *Nielsen Norman Group*. Available at: https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/ (Accessed: 8 February 2026).

W3C (2018) *Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1*. World Wide Web Consortium. Available at: https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/ (Accessed: 8 February 2026).

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'eBay UK | Electronics, Cars, Fashion, Collectibles & More' (2024) *eBay UK*. Available at: https://www.ebay.co.uk/ (Accessed: 8 February 2026).

'Gumtree | Free Classified Ads from the #1 Classifieds Site in the UK' (no date) *Gumtree*. Available at: https://www.gumtree.com/ (Accessed: 8 February 2026).

Assignment 1 for DUX Kai, Will and Daniel - Remake of Craigslist UI (Craigslist London) to follow modern design principles, be accessible and open